

German led to assignments in Army intelligence, and toward the end of World War II to a role in military government, overseeing a district of occupied Germany.

After the war, he won admission to Harvard, graduated with high honors, and went on to gain a doctorate in history, crafting a prize-winning dissertation on the Congress of Vienna and the end of the Napoleonic Wars. He used this to gain admission to analytical ranks at the Council on Foreign Relations and to the Rockefeller Brothers Fund, a policy research and advisory institute. He also served as rapporteur for study groups on national security issues, then turned his notes into books.

As Kissinger's stature increased, Harvard invited him back as a lecturer. He directed a prestigious Defense Studies Program, attended by future world leaders, and became a professor in 1962.



Mr. Fix It

Kissinger talks with Mao Zedong in 1973. Kissinger's first visit to China in July 1971 recognized the legitimacy of the People's Republic and prepared the ground for President Nixon's visit in 1972.

Right-hand man

By this time, Kissinger was already advising the US president. He counseled President Kennedy on the 1961 Berlin Crisis—a Cold War confrontation over the status of Berlin—and advised both Kennedy and President Johnson on Vietnam.

Kissinger remained close to Republican Party circles even as he assisted Johnson on Vietnam peace feelers. It was said, and not refuted, that Kissinger supplied inside information to Republican candidate Richard Nixon during the 1968 presidential election. After the election, Nixon made him his national security adviser.

Kissinger's penchant for tactics quickly became clear—he set the bureaucracy to work on extensive policy reviews on every imaginable subject, diverting its staff while he created National Security Council (NSC) mechanisms for key policy areas, including Vietnam. Kissinger then used these NSC sub-committees to take control of policies in selected areas.